Annual Reports on the Working of the Native Passenger Ships Act were more thorough.

However, though SSNCo was winning the battle, it was losing the war. S.D. Krishna Aiyangar argued that, given the 'novel nature' of the shipping business, indigenous companies could not stand the competition from well-established British companies. While he would countenance other forms of competition, he objected to 'rate cutting'. Describing it as 'unfair', he explained it thus: 'The BI took passengers free, and on a particular day they gave clothes free to the passengers as presents. When a company of such splendid resources had recourse to such unfair means, our company found it absolutely impossible to stand the strain. We were losing heavily, without the least chance of that competition being removed.'[138]

More than a decade after the Swadeshi movement, Walchand Hirachand, the doyen of Indian shipping, recalled: 'The foreign companies even went to the length of carrying passengers for free and in the case of the Tuticorin company they not only carried the passengers free but they also gave a handkerchief as a present to the passengers …'[139] As Asoka Mehta remarked, 'The same tale can be told over and over again to explain the destruction of other shipping enterprises.'[140]

BI of course denied any wrongdoing. If it defended its right to indulge in cut-throat practices at that time—for instance, at the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee hearings—its official history, written in the high noon of decolonization, whitewashed the life and death struggle of the fledgling company with the words, '[the] whole story of the Indian effort in the field of shipping, and of the little freight and rate wars that inevitably ensued is long and really tedious'. Referring to the internecine wars between shipping companies at the turn of the twentieth century, BI's official historian dubbed it 'an old, dusty story'. Who now remembers them, he asked, forgetting that injustices are rarely forgotten. Further, Indian efforts were dismissed as little more than attempts to take 'advantage of the prevalent climate of emotional nationalism'.[141] The blunt truth is that BI choked SSNCo.